

A dystopian reality check



Jayesh Shinde
Manager – Test Centre
jayesh.shinde@digit.in

"Technology has so pervaded our lives that it can't just be a domain exclusive to technical students, geeks or entrepreneurs anymore"

Popular sci-fi fiction has us humans reaching for the stars, having developed advanced cognitive systems, artificial intelligences and robots to help minimise the daily grind of our otherwise mundane futuristic lives. Jogging our brain only to take unfathomed leaps of creativity, ingenuity and empathy, we're the master of all races, slave to none. Not even to machines. Or so we'd like to think.

But what if I told you that very soon humanity's going to be so heavily reliant on digital systems and afflicted with large scale dementia that we won't remember what we had for dinner unless we looked up a digital memory of that event? That a Deus Ex Machina situation may never come to fruition due to severe cognitive regression among humans? Too far fetched? Let me make my case.

The Industrial Revolution led to machines aiding and eventually taking over from humans when it came to labour-intensive tasks and doing boringly repetitive actions to save both, our time and sanity levels. With less to do physically, human health suffered as a result, contributing to the rise in obesity. Caught in the middle of a new revolution, where digital systems are in the ascendancy, analysing huge swathes of data to make conclusive decisions with or without user input, we're increasingly falling into a dependency trap where we can't get much done without the help of a digital system. Our long-term mental capability will suffer as a result, by virtue of a simple fact of cognitive science: the less you exercise a mental skill, the progressively worse you get at it.

This applies to everything that we're trying to achieve without having to jog our brain or memory by trusting digital systems to think, store or act on our behalf. Services like Google Now and IBM Watson are the first steps along this path; needless to say, more radical and complex cognitive computing driven products are on their way. And they're all going to try to substitute our brain's ability to think, contributing to the rise in dementia to unprecedented levels over the next few decades. Of course, advances in medical science will try and mitigate this risk, but good luck trying to reverse decades of damage to your brain cells caused by mere inactivity.

That's one aspect to watch out for, brain slowdown, but here's another: an upswing in

the dispassionate use of technology at an alarmingly superficial level. Let me try and explain.

Gadgets these days are driven by designers. We're all busy admiring aesthetics and seem to ignore functionality. Increasingly simplified instances of computing in our lives are making us oblivious to the very technology that's simplifying our lives and the cost of our digital existence and inheritance. If technology is a critical part of our life and society at large, there's an even greater need for us to understand it from the inside out. To do this, in our own unique capacities, we need to get our hands dirty and wrap our heads around it in much the same way that a car owner would when it comes to owning an automobile – not every car owner is clued into the workings of the internal combustion engine, but it's in every driver's best interest to know basic troubleshooting, maintenance, fuel efficiency, mileage and, at a larger level, the environmental impact of automobiles – rather than just knowing how to drive. Similarly, coding knowledge is good to have but not an essential prerequisite to understand how technology works for us and impacts our life, just like you don't need to be a chef to recognise great taste, and more importantly a foul-smelling dish.

Technology has so pervaded our lives that it can't just be a domain exclusive to technical students, geeks or entrepreneurs anymore. All you need is curiosity, which is missing at large when it comes to understanding technology. And when curiosity manifests, it can't just be restricted to superficial levels – like admiring a gadget for how it looks, rather than how it functions. We need to dig deeper and be more intimate with digital systems and realise what we're getting into and what's at stake.

If we fail to get a grip on either the causes or effects of our day-to-day technology use, the dream of a sci-fi future may remain just that. With rising human apathy, our spirit of ingenuity will fast become a thing of the past. And that's a worrying thought. 

Got feedback about this column?
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jayesh.shinde@digit.in